



exactly as what we have seen earlier, in terms of the interface and usability, but Apple took the decision to remove certain critical Google services. That wasn't one of the best decisions by a long shot. Apple Maps has become the laughing stock globally, for its complete incompetence. We know people who have painfully downgraded their iPhones back to iOS 5. For anyone who doesn't need the navigation guidance on the iPhone, the iPhone 5 with iOS 6 is a delightful experience. The newer and more powerful processor, more RAM and bumped up graphics chip – the perfect recipe for a very good smartphone. Good? Well, we are being modest!

Samsung Galaxy Note II

What the first generation Galaxy Note did was to bring the hybrid device between the smartphone and the tablet to the masses. The popularity of the Note surprised us as well, admittedly. What the Note II does is build on that, with a lot more power, an even bigger display and the very latest OS on board. Consumers who prefer a big screen device are the ones who are in surprisingly huge numbers. You have the alternative in the LG Optimus VU, but the Galaxy Note II is just far superior as a whole – the latest OS, excellent performance and very good build quality.

Mid-range

The mid-range smartphones launched in 2012 were fairly impressive. Dual-core processors became sort of the norm for Android phones. But the major excitement came from price-cuts that saw a lot of 2011's excellent phones become more affordable. While we cannot consider them for this edition of the awards, we must mention that the truly amazing Motorola Razr and the fairly competent HTC Sensation XE are now available below ₹25,000. The Windows Phone enthusiasts will be delighted to hear that the Lumia 800 also saw a price cut, bringing it down to below ₹20,000.

Zero1 Winner

HTC One S

When it was launched, we were quite aghast that HTC had priced it very close to the quad-core processor powered One X. But, over a period of time,



Sony Xperia P

Price: ₹22,990



Nokia 808 PureView

Price: ₹25,000

the market corrections have brought the HTC One S's price to just below ₹25,000. In this category, it is by far the best performer. When we had reviewed this phone, the benchmark tests made for interesting reading – the scores were well ahead of any dual-core phone in that category and running after the quad-cores rather consistently. It has a fairly good camera and is in line for the Android Jelly Bean update. This leaves no doubt that the One S is by far the fastest phone under ₹25,000 and is a good option to consider.

Worthy Mentions

Sony Xperia P

One thing that went in its favour straightaway was its excellent build quality. The design is very similar to the more expensive Xperia S, and the build quality isn't inferior in any way. Took some time to catch the consumers' attention, because Sony inexplicably sent it initially with Android GingerBread, when phones were coming out of the box with Ice Cream Sandwich. The update took care of that problem, and the Xperia P is one of those consistent performers that know their limits and work well within them. Consider this if unique looks are important to you. Do remember, this has a slightly smaller display than the One S.

Nokia 808 PureView

You may be slightly surprised to see this phone mentioned here, but the price changes have also brought this down to ₹25,000 and thereabouts. Yes, Symbian is not the slickest OS around, but do remember that you will get all the popular apps on the Nokia Store. But the biggest factor is the PureView 41 MP camera, which is pretty much unmatched in terms of the performance. Buy this phone if you do take a lot of pictures.



◀ MID-RANGE:

HTC ONE S

Price: ₹24,990